

Westpac-Now Q1 2026 second estimate

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By Pat Bustamante

Senior Economist, Westpac

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Westpac Now points to moderating growth even before the RBA's rate hikes took effect on the economy, with recent confidence weakness not yet feeding through to activity but posing a growing downside risk.



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- Consistent with our first estimate, Westpac Now points to GDP growth of around 0.6%qtr in Q1 2026 (range: 0.55–0.75%qtr), lifting year ended growth to 2.8%yr.
- Our monthly activity index edged lower in March after moving sideways through January and February. Overall, activity was flat across the March quarter, ending an upswing that began in May 2025 even before the recent tightening in monetary policy could take effect.
- Recent sharp falls in consumer and business confidence were largely ‘looked through’; our framework would take more signal from a sustained drop.
- While growth appear to have remained resilient in Q1, a prolonged Middle East conflict increases the risk that weak confidence spills over into a broader set of indicators (many of which have already softened), exacerbating supply chain dislocations and lower real incomes.
- Our framework suggests growth will ease to around 0.5%qtr in Q2, before returning to 0.6%qtr in Q3 2026, but these estimates by design do not allow for the wider effect of the conflict and differ from our actual GDP forecasts.

Westpac Now updates are released monthly, with details in Appendix A.

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